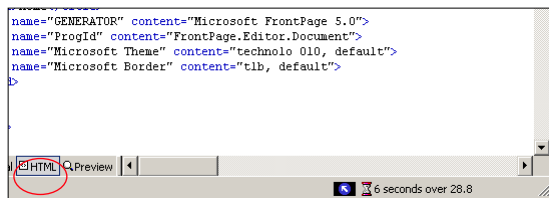


Next, you look at the Meta Keywords tag. At one time, all search engines would rank sites based on this tag alone. However, people have learned to exploit, or rather, abuse this tag to gain rankings. Today, this tag has little or no effect on your rankings, and most search engines ignore this tag. You should, however, enter your keywords into this tag anyway: a little optimism never hurt anyone!

The last tag, the Alt Tag, is the tag you add to your images. This pops up text as a tooltip when your mouse hovers over an image in a browser.

Try and insert your keywords into most of your Alt Tags, but make sure they make sense. Also, try not to go overboard with really long Alt Tags because some people still use non-graphical browsers to navigate, and will see your Alt Tags as text instead of as images—this will ruin the way your page looks when viewed in a non-graphical browser.

Before you scorn this minority, remember that all major search engine spiders—the very bots that rank our site—crawl the Net non-graphically.



Look for the HTML button on the bottom left of the page you are editing to see your Meta tags, and to change them

A Thousand Words

The second-most important search engine optimisation is the actual body text of your site. Make sure that the keywords you are optimising your site for are repeated as often as possible within the body text of your site. Don't just go about adding "second-hand", "cars" and "Mumbai" everywhere! Instead, write intelligently and work your keywords into the text so that it reads well, and most importantly, makes sense.

...A Little Help From My Friends

By far, the most important criterion for your site's ranking with any search engine is one you do not control. The majority of search engines give the highest



Get Proactive

After you are done creating and optimising your site, don't just sit around and wait for search engines to discover you. Instead, make them take notice by submitting your URL to them. Here are the major search engines around the world that people use. Once they have you on their database, pretty soon everyone else will too.

☐ All The Web / Yahoo!

<http://submit.search.yahoo.com/free/request>

☐ Google

<http://www.google.com/addurl.html>

☐ Inktomi

<http://submitit.bcentral.com/msnsubmit.htm>

☐ MSN

<http://submitit.bcentral.com/msnsubmit.htm>

☐ The Open Directory Project (DMOZ) / Ask Jeeves / Lycos

<http://dmoz.org/add.html>

importance to how many other sites link to your site. This seems to be the only fair way of ranking a Web site today—if it were left to just the tags and body text, we would find nothing but useless sites with every search we did.

The logic is simple. If you are as good as you say you are, others will acknowledge it, and inform people about your products and services. It is a good idea to start off by getting a friend or non-rival company to add a link to your site from theirs, as soon as your site is up. Of course, you should also repay the favour, and make sure to add links to their sites in return.

If the sites that link to you have already been indexed by search engines, the spiders or bots will soon be back to find changes in them. When the spiders return, they will find a link to your site, and will automatically pay your site a visit. You should make sure that the link from the other site contains your site's keywords. Sometimes, it may seem strange to have a link exchange with, say, a textile company. It would really look odd if your auto dealership linked to a textile site, and vice versa. You can overcome this by adding ghost links or hidden links to the other Web site.

In order to make a hidden link, just create a small picture that is the same colour as your background colour. Now, place this image at the very bottom of your page, and link it to whichever site you want. This link will not be visible, but search engine spiders will find it nonetheless. The reason you should always place it at the

bottom of your page is so that search engines do not show its Alt Tag when displaying your site in the results.

Justifying The Means

The more effort you put into optimising your Web site, the higher your rank will be. Link exchanges are always a good thing, though you should be wary of which sites you link to—even with hidden links. You do not want your reputable auto-dealership linking to a pornography Web site, for example. Your customers would not like to even accidentally click on a hidden link and be taken to a porn site when shopping online with the family for a new car.

In just a few days, you should be able to have a well-designed and well-optimised site up and running. Typically, it can take anywhere from a week to 3 months for your site to be found by search engines—depending mainly on which sites link to you. You should also submit your site to the top search engines manually—see box "Get Proactive" above.

Once you are done, all that's left is to make sure your site is updated regularly, has no dead links and always has relevant content. Whether or not you actually make it to the top depends solely on the dedication you put into constantly optimising your site, and getting popular Web sites to link to you. All you need is the will, Microsoft Frontpage, and, of course, *Digit*, to do so. If you manage to reach rank number one on major search engines, send us a mail at editor@thinkdigit.com and share your experience. ☐

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